

Chapter Fifteen

The Version Outside the Window

By the time Nora got home, the evening had turned cold enough to make her fingers ache.

She stood outside her apartment door for almost a full minute before unlocking it. Not because she was afraid of what waited inside, but because, for once, nothing did.

No crisis.

No missed emergency.

No body waiting to borrow her.

Just the apartment.

The quiet.

Her own life.

She entered slowly, as if the room might startle.

Her keys landed in the bowl by the door. Her coat went over the chair instead of on the hook. The hospital smell still clung faintly to her hair and sleeves, antiseptic and coffee and tired air.

She carried the paper bag of pears into the kitchen.

Tomas had made her take them back.

“Remove the traitors,” he had said.

Now they sat on her counter, green and innocent, accused of crimes they did not understand.

Nora touched one with her fingertip and smiled.

Then the smile faded.

Do not climb onto her back.

Tomas's voice stayed with her. Not cruel. Not unkind. Just clear in the way people became clear when illness had taken their patience for soft lies.

Nora leaned against the counter.

For once, the truth did not feel stolen. It felt handed to her, heavy and direct.

That should have made it easier to carry.

It did not.

Her phone buzzed.

Maya.

Dad says one pear escaped. Check your pockets.

Nora laughed.

A second message came.

Thank you for today.

Nora typed:

Thank you for letting me come.

She hesitated, then added:

I'll try harder.

Maya replied:

I know. But also sleep.

Nora stared at the words.

I know.

Once, those words had felt like judgment.

Now they felt like a hand resting briefly on her shoulder.

She placed the phone down and began making tea.

Halfway through filling the kettle, her doorbell rang.

Nora froze.

Not a knock inside her.

Not pressure.

The real bell.

She went to the door and looked through the peephole.

Adam stood in the hallway holding two paper cups and a small white box.

Nora opened the door.

“You brought something,” she said.

“Tea,” he said. “And cake.”

“I already have tea.”

“Then now you have superior tea.”

“What kind of cake?”

“Lemon.”

She stepped aside. “Accepted.”

Adam entered with the quiet caution that had become familiar, but less strained than before. He removed his coat, hung it properly because he was Adam, and placed the cups and box on the kitchen table.

Then he saw the pears.

“Are those the abandoned apples?”

“Careful. They’re sensitive.”

“I heard they gave up.”

Nora smiled.

For a moment, they were easy.

The ease frightened her more than awkwardness.

Adam took two plates from the cabinet without asking. The old habit should have bothered her, but it didn't. Some intimacies were not invasions. Some were simply evidence of having belonged somewhere for a long time.

They sat at the kitchen table with lemon cake between them.

Adam looked tired.

Nora noticed the shadows beneath his eyes, the looseness in his shoulders. He had been careful with her for days. Careful with Maya. Careful with himself last, if at all.

"You look exhausted," she said.

He lifted an eyebrow. "That is usually my line."

"I'm borrowing it."

"Please return it in good condition."

She picked at the edge of her cake. "Have you slept?"

"Some."

"That means no."

"It means some."

"Adam."

He sighed. "Not much."

Guilt stirred.

Nora almost took it and made it hers.

Then stopped.

"You need rest," she said.

"So do you."

“Yes, but we are discussing you.”

He studied her for a second, as if surprised to find the conversation pointed his way.

That made her sad.

“When was the last time someone asked how you are?” she said.

Adam looked down at his tea.

There it was.

A small silence.

Not secretive.

Unused.

“I don’t know,” he said.

Nora felt something inside her soften.

Not pressure.

Not pull.

Care.

Ordinary care.

“Then I’m asking,” she said.

Adam gave a faint smile. “I’m tired.”

“That’s the surface answer.”

“It’s the available answer.”

“Okay.”

He looked at her, cautious.

She did not push.

After a while, his expression changed.

“I’m scared,” he said.

Nora’s hand stilled near her cup.

“Of the jumps?”

“Yes. And no.”

“Of me?”

His eyes lifted quickly. “No.”

The answer was immediate.

Too immediate.

Nora waited.

Adam closed his eyes. “Not of you. Of losing you to them.”

The room quieted.

He continued slowly, as if each word required permission.

“When you disappear, even for seconds, there’s nothing I can do. Your body is there, but you’re not. I don’t know if you’re breathing because your body remembers how, or because some part of you is still holding on. I don’t know if you can get trapped. I don’t know if one day you’ll come back carrying so much of someone else that there won’t be enough room for you.”

Nora’s throat tightened.

Adam looked at his hands.

“And then I hate myself because part of me keeps thinking in systems. Patterns. Triggers. Rules. I keep trying to make it solvable because if it isn’t solvable, then all I can do is watch.”

Nora reached across the table.

Stopped.

“Can I?”

Adam looked at her.

Something flickered in his face. Gratitude, maybe. Or grief.

“Yes.”

She took his hand.

No jump came.

Only warmth.

Adam’s fingers closed around hers.

“I don’t want you to have to fix me,” Nora said.

“I know.”

“I don’t want to become another impossible patient in your life.”

His mouth tightened. “You’re not a patient.”

“I know. But sometimes you look at me like I am a problem you love.”

The words hurt both of them.

She saw it.

Adam did not let go of her hand.

“That is unfair,” he said quietly.

“I know.”

“And not entirely wrong.”

Nora looked down.

He rubbed his thumb across her knuckles once.

“I’m trying,” he said.

“So am I.”

“I know.”

For a while, they sat with their hands linked across the table, lemon cake untouched.

Then Adam said, “Tomas was right.”

Nora laughed once. “About pears?”

“About Maya.”

Her smile faded.

“About you not climbing onto her back.”

Nora pulled her hand away slowly.

Adam noticed but did not reach again.

“I know,” she said.

“I don’t mean—”

“You do.”

He exhaled.

“Yes. I do.”

She folded her arms, not because she wanted distance, but because her body needed something to hold.

Adam leaned back.

“When Maya was in the car,” he said, “she was trying to protect you from her pain. But she was also trying to protect herself from your fear. Those are different things, and both matter.”

Nora stared at the table.

“I know.”

“And with me...” He stopped.

Nora looked up.

“With you what?”

Adam's jaw shifted.

"With me, sometimes I think you hear care as proof that I might leave."

The sentence struck too close.

Nora wanted to deny it.

She could not.

Adam continued, gently but without retreating. "When I ask if you're okay, you hear surveillance. When I worry, you hear doubt. When I help Maya, you hear replacement. When I step back, you hear abandonment."

Nora stood.

The chair scraped against the floor.

Adam went still.

She walked to the sink and gripped the edge.

Anger rose first, hot and clean because anger always came better dressed than shame.

"You came here to list my failures?"

"No."

"Because you're doing a very organized job."

"I came here because I love you, and I don't know how to keep loving you without saying the parts that are hurting me."

The anger stumbled.

Nora stared out the dark kitchen window.

Her reflection looked back at her, pale and sharp-eyed.

Behind it, Adam sat at the table, tired and careful and still there.

A version outside the window.

That was how she had begun to see everything lately: from outside, through glass, through distortion, through fear.

Adam helping Maya in the car.

Maya keeping her father's illness quiet.

Claire in the hallway.

Grace whispering in the library.

Her own family around the dinner table.

Every scene became a window. Every window made a story. Every story preferred the shape of Nora's fear.

She closed her eyes.

"What do you need?" she asked.

The question came out rough.

Adam did not answer immediately.

When he did, his voice was quiet.

"I need to be allowed to be tired."

Nora turned.

He looked embarrassed by the admission.

"I need to be able to say I'm scared without you becoming more scared of my fear than of the thing itself. I need to help Maya without feeling like every act of care is evidence against me. I need you to tell me when you're hurting before you make me the reason."

Nora's eyes burned.

"And," he added, softer, "I need you to believe that I am not always leaving when I am only standing somewhere you cannot see."

The sentence entered her slowly.

Then fully.

She covered her mouth with one hand.

Adam looked down.

“I don’t know if that’s too much,” he said.

“No,” Nora whispered.

Her voice broke.

“No, it’s not too much.”

She returned to the table and sat down.

“I don’t know how to do that yet,” she said.

“I know.”

“But I want to.”

Adam nodded.

“That matters.”

She laughed wetly. “Everyone keeps saying that.”

“Because it does.”

Silence settled between them.

Not empty.

Working.

Then Adam’s phone buzzed.

He glanced at it.

His face changed.

Nora saw it.

The old instinct rose instantly.

Who is it?

What happened?

Is it Maya?

Is it something you'll hide because you think I can't handle it?

Adam looked at her.

He knew.

For a second, neither moved.

Then he turned the phone so she could see.

Maya.

Message preview:

Dad wants to know if Nora ate the traitor pears.

Adam looked at Nora, waiting.

Not hiding.

Not defending.

Simply showing.

The gesture was small.

It broke her heart a little.

“He’s committed to this pear thing,” Adam said.

Nora laughed through tears. “He has one enemy and it is fruit.”

Adam smiled.

Then he answered Maya in front of her.

She has not. I am monitoring the situation.

Maya replied almost immediately.

Good. They cannot be trusted.

Nora's phone buzzed at the same time.

Maya again.

Are you with Adam?

Nora looked at the message.

Then at Adam.

"Yes," she typed.

Maya replied:

Good. Tell him not to look so haunted all the time.

Nora showed Adam.

He frowned. "I do not look haunted."

"You absolutely do."

"I look thoughtful."

"You look like a responsible ghost."

Adam looked offended.

Nora laughed.

For a brief moment, the triangle between them did not feel like a threat. It felt like what it had once been: three people who knew each other well enough to tease in the dark.

Then Maya sent one more message.

Also, please eat something real. Both of you.

Adam and Nora looked at the lemon cake.

"That counts," Adam said.

"No, it doesn't."

“It has lemon. That’s fruit.”

“Do not disrespect Tomas’s fruit trauma by calling cake fruit.”

Adam laughed, and the sound loosened the last of the hard air in the room.

They ordered food.

Real food.

While waiting, they cleared the table and talked about ordinary things badly at first, then better. Adam told her about a patient who kept asking if he could diagnose himself as “medically mysterious.” Nora told him about the library document called BORDERS. Adam wanted to read it. Nora said not yet. He accepted that.

When the food arrived, they ate on the couch.

Not close at first.

Then closer.

The television played a show neither watched.

At some point, Adam’s shoulder touched hers.

Nora noticed the contact.

Waited.

No pressure.

No pull.

Only Adam.

Tired. Warm. Present.

She leaned into him.

He did not make a big thing of it.

That was kind.

After a long while, Nora said, “I think my fear likes windows.”

Adam turned slightly. “What?”

“It likes seeing things from outside. Through glass. From across the street. Through phones. Through fragments. It likes distance because distance lets it invent the missing parts.”

Adam was quiet.

“And the jumps,” she continued, “they feel like the opposite. Like being too close. But somehow they can still be another window. I’m inside someone, and I still might only see the part fear wants.”

Adam nodded slowly.

“That sounds important.”

“I don’t know what to do with it.”

“Maybe just write it down.”

She smiled faintly. “You and your gentle homework.”

“It is a strong brand.”

Later, Adam fell asleep beside her.

Not fully. Just a doze, head tipped back against the couch, one hand resting open on his knee. The exhaustion finally caught him when he stopped holding himself upright for everyone else.

Nora watched him.

She thought about waking him so he could sleep properly.

Then stopped.

Do not turn care into control.

She got a blanket from the bedroom and placed it over him gently.

He stirred but did not wake.

His phone lay on the table.

Face down.

For one second, Nora looked at it.

No suspicion.

Only awareness of the old pathway.

The urge to check was quieter now, but not gone. Maybe it would never fully vanish. Maybe healing was not the absence of the door, but learning to pass it without entering.

She turned away.

At midnight, Adam woke with a start.

“What time is it?”

“Late.”

“I should go.”

“You can stay.”

He looked at her, not assuming.

“Asleep stay,” she clarified. “On the couch. Or in the bed. Wherever. No pressure.”

His face softened.

“Are you sure?”

“I’m sure.”

He studied her.

Then nodded.

They slept in her bed with space between them at first. Then, sometime in the dark, Nora woke to find her hand resting against his arm.

Still herself.

Still here.

Morning came pale and quiet.

Adam was already awake, staring at the ceiling.

Nora turned toward him.

“Did you sleep?”

“A little.”

“That means no.”

He smiled.

Then his smile faded.

“Nora?”

“Yes?”

“I need to tell you something before it becomes a secret.”

Her body went cold.

He felt it.

“It’s not bad,” he said quickly. “Or maybe it is. I don’t know. But it is something I should not avoid because I’m afraid of your reaction.”

Nora sat up slowly.

The room seemed to sharpen around them.

Adam did too, pushing himself upright against the headboard.

“Maya asked me yesterday if I thought you were safe,” he said.

Nora could not speak.

“She didn’t mean dangerous,” Adam added. “Not exactly. She meant emotionally safe. For herself. For her father. For me. For you.”

The words landed one by one.

Nora looked down at the blanket.

“She asked you that?”

“Yes.”

“And what did you say?”

Adam’s face tightened.

“I said I didn’t know yet.”

Nora closed her eyes.

There it was.

Not betrayal.

Not cruelty.

Something worse because it was honest.

The people she loved were discussing whether she was safe.

And they had reason.

Adam reached for her, then stopped.

“I’m telling you because hiding it would make it worse.”

Nora nodded.

But the nod did not mean she was all right.

A familiar pressure touched the back of her eyes.

Not strong.

Not yet.

Adam saw her face change.

“Nora?”

She opened her eyes.

The room held.

Adam held.

But somewhere inside her, fear had found a new window.

Maya and Adam talking about her.

Maya asking if she was safe.

Adam saying he did not know.

The scene formed instantly, cruelly detailed though she had not seen it.

Nora pressed both hands to her temples.

“No.”

Adam sat forward. “Stay with me.”

“I’m trying.”

“Nora, look at me.”

She did.

His face blurred.

Then cleared.

“I told you,” he said. “I brought it into the room. Stay in this room with me.”

The pressure trembled.

For one impossible second, Nora felt the door waiting.

Not open.

Waiting.

She breathed.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

The pressure faded.

Slowly.

Painfully.

But it faded.

Nora lowered her hands.

Adam looked as if he might cry.

“You stayed,” he whispered.

Nora’s whole body shook.

“No,” she said.

Her voice was hoarse.

“We stayed.”

And for the first time, the closed door felt like something they had held shut together.